Douglas Dillon contended that 'It's a *totally* different world today, and as far as I can see, the Cuban missile crisis has little relevance in today's world.'[5] In 1962 Dillon was Kennedy's Treasury Secretary, and one of the President's advisors. He described himself as a 'hawk' who favoured military action against Cuba. Other advisers took very different views in 1962 and in 1987. They believed there were lessons to be learned. Former Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara and national security assistant McGeorge Bundy saw one key lesson was that the best way of managing a nuclear crisis was to avoid having one in the first place. Yet, they also drew lessons that it was possible to calibrate the threat – and use – of force to coerce an adversary. Critics believe this was a recipe for disaster in Vietnam. Drawing the wrong lessons can be worse than not drawing any lessons at all.

The Russian invasion of Ukraine in February prompted several comparisons with the Cuban missile crisis. Some indeed have invoked the missile crisis as a guide in assisting Vladimir Putin craft an exit strategy from his war on Ukraine. In March 2022 Rishi Paul and Nicholas Wheeler contended that the 'the closest historical parallel to the current situation [the Russian invasion of Ukraine] is the Cuban missile crisis.' They argue:

> the lesson from the peaceful ending of the Cuban Missile Crisis [may be the] reluctant conclusion … that reducing the risks of nuclear use depends on finding an 'off-ramp' that simultaneously does not reward Putin nor leave him humiliated or desperate. Putin has core security interests at stake in this crisis and they will have to be acknowledged in any settlement.[6]

Some years after the crisis, JFK's Secretary of State, Dean Rusk, invoked the dictum of Sun Tzu (the Chinese philosopher of war in the 5th century BCE) that you should build your opponent 'a golden bridge' over which to retreat.[7] There are, of course, examples in history where building golden bridges behind opponents is wholly counterproductive, as in battles of encirclement from Cannae to Stalingrad to Falaise. Many commentators (and, more importantly, political leaders) have argued that giving Putin an